▼ WOMEN IN SPACE: PUSHING THE FRONTIER

TAKEAWAYS

» "It's not hard work, it's work smart. It's very important where you want to focus, what talent you want to improve, so focus on that and improve it"
Prof. Annapurni Subramaniam

» "Societal stigma makes us feel that we will not be able to do many things. Have the self-belief in your abilities, and work hard and persevere because, then, you will be able to do anything, what we pursue and what we really love to do and have a passion for"
Nigar Shaji

and social rights and representation in leadership.

"Equity is the route to equality," said Saundarya Rajesh, in a session on building a diverse organisation. Studies have shown that organisations with a diverse workforce thrive. Rajesh concurred, as she revealed how her Avtar Group runs an extensive diversity analytics exercise to identify the best companies for women. "Flexibility at work" emerged as a major factor. But "actual change", she said, only happens "when you have women at the top". Pursuit of balance, Rajesh noted, is pointless; instead, she advocated "work-life integration".

Suchitra Ella is no stranger to power. When asked to highlight the special leadership qualities that women bring to management and that men don't have, Ella shunned the gender-bashing route. "I think women are natural multi-taskers... You can just focus on multiple things at a given point of time and it doesn't rattle you to that extent that you are going to be worried about what's going to happen at home or the office." The mother of two elaborated on how working mothers often experience guilt if they spend long hours at work. "Sometimes, it is tough to handle, but I did not give in to that. I said having children is not an excuse for not going to work," Ella said, adding how she had her children do homework in her office if they needed her.

Both Ella and Aruna Sairam singled out the importance of having supportive partners. Sairam used the opportunity to thank her husband, also present in the audience, who resigned from his job in Mumbai and moved to Chennai in 2002 so that her music career could flourish. "Please look out for the women in your life," Sairam said. "She may have something out there which is not being expressed or bottled up for various reasons... Look out for it. Give it that little hand of love and care, and see where she will go. You will be proud of her."

Not every individual, though, has their family's backing. That was true for Narthaki Nataraj, who came out as a transgender at the tender age of 10. Nataraj spoke of the obstacles and the ostracisation she faced in her village. "When I open the door of my house, I never feel the freedom breeze," she recalled. "I know what I'm going to face—

Photographs by CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



(From left) **Saundarya Rajesh,** *Founder-president, Avtar Group;* **Lavanya Nalli**, *Vice Chairperson, Nalli Group of Companies;* **Dr Urjitha Rajagopalan**, *Director, MGM Healthcare*

▲ DISCUSSION: BUILDING A DIVERSE ORGANISATION

TAKEAWAYS

» "The first thing is to make a commitment to yourself, a pledge that you will stay in the workforce no matter what. There might be a little detour along the way, but you promise yourself that you will come back because in your economic self-sufficiency lies your economic independence, which is key to your empowerment. Stay career-intentional"
Saundarya Rajesh

» "There's a saying, 'Choose Your Hard', which is a riff on life being hard. Marriage is hard, being single is hard, getting divorced is hard, work is hard, being a stay-at-home mom is hard. I'd say, 'Choose your hard'. You might want to optimise for economic independence. Trust me, having that opportunity is empowering"
Lavanya Nalli

» "Self-advocacy is something that each woman must do for herself.... It involves embracing and advocating for yourself at every stage of your life"
Dr Urjitha Rajagopalan